

'SO LONG, DOC. YOU WILL BE MISSED'

Indian sport lost a **precious gem** with the passing of Dr. Vece Paes.

My first meeting with Doc was in 1981, on the eve of the match in Calcutta during the India-Pakistan Test series. He had come over to our team hotel with his little son to wish us the best. In the middle of our banter and conversation, Doc realised he had to make a visit to some of his patients. "I'm leaving Leander with you chaps. Give him a feel of what it is like to be part of an Indian team. Will come by to pick him up later in the day," said Doc, and he zoomed off.

It was a fun day for Leander as we took him along through our daily drill. Doc's friendly demeanour despite his seniority, and Leander's interest to learn, struck a chord. It was the beginning of a special friendship with father and son.

The very next year, in 1982, I was representing my then employers Mahindra & Mahindra in the Aga Khan tournament in Bombay. In the semifinals we were up against the formidable Pakistan International Airlines (PIA), comprising almost their entire national team that had won the World Cup earlier that year.

After going toe-to-toe with them in a high-paced match, we lost 1-2 due to a late goal. As we trudged back into the Bombay Gymkhana dressing room, a disheartened lot, we noticed a gift-wrapped parcel for the team. It turned out to be a crate of canned beer with a congratulatory note from Doc Paes. It certainly lifted our spirits! The empathy shown for the losing team by a



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senior pro, who just happened to be a spectator that day, further enhanced my respect for the man.

After my playing career, in 1989, I was appointed to the National Selection Committee that comprised Doc Paes among other stalwarts. His clarity of thought, without an iota of bias, positively influenced decision-making. I got to know him better, and we hung out some evenings together. He spoke about Leander's passion to excel in

tennis at the highest level.

Sponsorship by corporate houses for individual athletes did not exist back then. Doc decided to sacrifice his medical practice for some years to manage Leander's career and tap every possible source to generate finances. He had identified Gene Mayer in the USA, a top-rung coach, to fine-tune Leander's technical skills. Mayer charged a then-hefty fee of 1,000 USD for a single session. Doc somehow scrambled together the resources to make it happen. Looking back, critical interventions like these set Leander up, ultimately earning him a place in the International Tennis Hall of Fame.

In time, Doc Paes became the face of sports medicine in India. His deep knowledge enabled him to add scientific temper to training, fitness, and recovery. **Besides hockey, his expertise was sought in a wide range of games, including cricket, football, and rugby. He played a key role in setting protocols to detect age fraud and deter those taking performance-enhancing substances.**

Despite his many accomplishments in sport and in the